Microsoft has taken this forward with the concept of Sender ID, which is to e-mail what caller ID is to a phone. The Sender ID concept works on the basis of the IP address of the sending server, which is checked against a registered list of servers that the domain owner has authorised to send e-mail. This verification is automatically checked, before the mail is delivered, by the ISP or the mail server of the recipient.

6.5 Pretty Good Privacy

No method of protection is absolutely foolproof. However, a big step in ensuring e-mail protection is PGP or Pretty Good Privacy. PGP is essentially a data encrypting program which provides privacy and authentication. The theory behind it is that messages are encrypted so that no one but the intended receiver can decrypt them.

PGP can technically be used to encrypt any form of data. However, it is most commonly used for sending e-mails and Internet fax.

6.5.1 How it works

Essentially, PGP works like a coding machine from those early war movies. It codes the message into an algorithm that can only be decoded if the same passphrase that the coder used to code the message is used by the decoder. The software makes use of keys and “keyrings”. Keys are basically of two types—public and private. The public key, as the name suggests, is basically the location of your mailbox. PGP allows you to send the public key to whoever you like (hence the term “public”). So anyone who has the public key knows the location of your mailbox and can send you e-mails at the key address. However, only those who know the private key can open the message and read it.

Using a simple analogy, the public key is the address of your home. Anyone can send you letters using that address. These let-